visiting religious places than work-related. They might have a case here. An ardent follower of Dada Bhagwan, Bhupendra Patel maintains that his chair is nothing but a blessing from his guru. "He speaks little," says a BJP leader from Ahmedabad, "and when you ask him about his political ambitions, he points towards the statue of Dada Bhagwan. The guru, it seems, will show the path."

As elections near, Patel has ensured that the state budget has adequate provisions for three key constituencies—farmers, tribals and women—in line with the BJP's poll strategy. Even at an early May *chintan baithak* (brainstorming sitting), Union home minister Amit Shah was heard exhorting BJP workers to focus on these three sections as they were crucial if the party was to retain power after December.

No one can accuse Patel of not following orders from New Delhi. A Gujarat Natural Farming Development Board, in accordance with Modi's thrust on organic farming, has been constituted, the compensation to farmers whose land has been acquired for erecting power transmission towers has been doubled to 15 per cent (above the market rate); the state also bears 10 per cent of the cost (up to Rs 1,500) if a farmer wants to buy a smartphone. There is also a Rs 1,046 crore provision to complete electrification of their farmlands.

As for the tribals, financial assistance for students from the community pursuing a Ph.D. has been increased from Rs 25,000 to Rs 1 lakh. Plans are also under way to erect 500 new mobile towers in tribal areas for better connectivity. Around 16,500 tribal families have been awarded land rights under the Forest Rights Act. The state has also increased the budget for women's empowerment programmes by 42 per cent—178 government programmes focus solely on this. But Patel's biggest success so far has been the 'Suposhit Mata, Swasth Bal Yojana', for which Rs 850 crore has been set aside. Under the scheme, 1 kg toor dal, 2 kg chana dal and one litre edible oil is provided free every month for 1,000 days to pregnant women and lactating mothers.

The Dalit, tribal challenge

For CM Patel, winning the hearts of the 15 per cent scheduled tribe (ST) and six per cent scheduled caste (SC) population will be the biggest challenge. Out of the 182 seats in the assembly, 26 are reserved for STs and 13 for SCs. In 2017, the BJP had won 21 of these 39 seats (13 ST and eight SC), with the Congress taking 15 (Independents had won three seats). An India Today-My Axis exit poll survey said that 48 per cent of the STs and 32 per cent SCs had voted for the BJP in 2017.

FOR CM BHUPENDRA PATEL, WINNING THE HEARTS OF THE ALIENATED 15% ST AND 6% SC POPULATION WILL BE THE BIG CHALLENGE

The situation has changed since then. The tribals are vehemently opposed to the Union government's plan to interlink three rivers—Par, Tapi and Narmada, calling it a plan to displace them from their native lands. Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman had announced the project, aimed at increasing irrigation facilities in Gujarat and Maharashtra, in her budget speech this year. On March 30, the state government had to request the Union government to put the project on hold following the protests.

On the political front, the BJP faces a tough challenge from the Bharatiya Tribal Party (BTP), a regional force in the tribal areas. The BTP is likely to join hands with the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in the coming election. BTP president Mahesh Vasava, the MLA from Dedipada in Narmada district, has been running a vociferous campaign against the BJP government. He had called on AAP chief and Delhi CM Arvind Kejriwal in the national capital in March. Vasava alleges the BJP is trying to portray all the tribals as Maoists. He also objects to being called *vanvasis* (forest residents). "We don't just live there, we are the owners of the forest," he argues.

Talks of an alliance between the BTP and AAP are still at the primary level though. State AAP convenor Gopal Italia says, "It is a big political decision for both parties, so we cannot rush matters." But former BJP legislator Bharat Pandya brushes aside the possibility of a dent in the BJP's tribal votes. "Our government is working for their betterment, the tribals have full faith in PM Modi," he says. At the same time, the party is not taking any chances—a host of interactions and rallies have been scheduled for PM Modi in the tribal areas.

It hasn't helped that the Bhupendra Patel regime has been called out for its 'anti-tribal' stand. The CM, who also holds the home portfolio, has come in for some fiery criticism from even the RSS affiliate organisation, the Samajik Samrasta Manch (SSM), for shielding Yogeshdan Gadhvi, a folk singer accused of bad-mouthing the SC community. A popular face on TV, Gadhvi allegedly used derogatory language to describe the SC community at a party function and in the presence of state BJP president C.R. Patil on May 14. An offence under the SC and ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act was filed against Gadhvi, but he has not been arrested yet. CM Patel apparently